

WEDNESDAY, JULY 15, 2026

The Indian EXPRESS

JOURNALISM of COURAGE

NEW DELHI, LATE CITY, 22 PAGES

₹7.00 (₹8 RAIPUR, ₹15 SRINAGAR) • www.indianexpress.com

DAILY FROM: AHMEDABAD, CHANDIGARH, DELHI, JAIPUR, KOLKATA, LUCKNOW, MUMBAI, NAGPUR, PATNA, PUNE, VADODARA

Bhojshala dispute: SC orders Friday prayers at alternative site

Bench declines to pass order restoring status quo, will examine dispute in detail

Express News Service
New Delhi, July 14

THE SUPREME Court declined to pass any order restoring status quo at the disputed Bhojshala-Kamal Maula mosque complex in Madhya Pradesh and directed that Muslim worshippers be provided an alternative space adjacent to the premises for Friday prayers until it examines the dispute in detail.

On May 15, the Madhya Pradesh High Court had held that



The Bhojshala-Kamal Maula mosque complex in MP

the complex has a religious character as a temple, following

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

TRUMP U-TURN: NO HORMUZ TRANSIT FEE, WANT TRADE, INVESTMENT DEALS INSTEAD

Another Indian killed as Iran hits UAE tankers in Hormuz

MEA summons Iran’s deputy chief of mission, lodges protest

Shubhajit Roy
New Delhi, July 14

AS THE US and Iran stepped up attacks and battled for control over the Strait of Hormuz, two UAE-flagged oil tankers with Indian seafarers came under fire from Tehran on Tuesday, leaving one dead and 10 injured. The Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) summoned the Iranian Deputy Chief of Mission and lodged a strong protest.



A vessel at the Strait of Hormuz, as seen from Oman, Tuesday.

REUTERS RELATED REPORTS, P 16

(Reuters adds: US President Donald Trump stepped back from a proposal to charge a 20% transit fee to guard the strait, saying he would instead seek investment deals with Gulf states. US forces carried

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

Dashboard to monitor seafarers, liaison officers for families, says Govt

Vikas Pathak
New Delhi, July 14

WITH ANOTHER Indian seafarer being killed in the US-Iran conflict, the Centre on Tuesday ordered a series of measures, including an operational dashboard to track every Indian on every vessel — regardless of the country it belongs to — and a dedicated liaison officer for every seafarer who is killed or injured, to act as the “single

point of contact” for the affected family.

The decisions were taken at an inter-ministerial meeting chaired by Sarbananda Sonowal, Union Minister of Ports, Shipping and Waterways, soon after the fresh attacks on two oil tankers with Indian crew on Tuesday.

According to sources in the ministry, nine Indian seafarers have died, one is presumed

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

Amid new US tariff plan, Govt prohibits import of goods made using forced labour

Ravi Dutta Mishra
New Delhi, July 14

THE COMMERCE and Industry Ministry on Tuesday prohibited the import of goods manufactured using forced labour, weeks after the United States Trade Representative (USTR) proposed 12.5 per cent tariffs on India linked to the issue.

The US had launched two Section 301 probes on India in March and subsequently proposed fresh tariffs on June 3 after the outcome of its first investigation found that India failed to “effectively enforce” a forced labour import prohibition, which had purportedly hurt US commerce. The outcome of the second investigation relating to excess capacity is yet to be released.

The Directorate General of Foreign Trade (DGFT), in an order dated July 13, has inserted a new paragraph in the Foreign Trade Policy (FTP) regarding “forced labour”, stating that the

E. EXPLAINED

Global benchmark

Experts say the notification on forced labour indicates India is tightening its domestic legal framework to match global benchmarks. The move could strengthen its position in trade negotiations and discussions on market access.

import of goods produced or manufactured, “wholly or in part”, through the use of forced labour is “prohibited”.

“The Central Government may, from time to time, specify, by notification, the goods whose import shall be prohibited under this paragraph, having regard to the findings of such enquiry or such other material as it may consider appropriate. The procedure for

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

INDIAN EXPRESS UPSC IAS EDITION HD 15~07~2026

-:FOR UPSC IAS ASPIRANTS:-

"AVOID POLITICAL & IRRELEVANT ARTICLES"

Please Try To Read This Completely in 40 Minutes If You

Can't So Then You Have To Increase Your Efforts

All the topics of this UPSC IAS Edition are directly or

indirectly important for the prelims & main examination.

There are some topics which can be coded in answer writing

of other topics in the main exam.

[FROM PAGE 1 | FULL REPORTS ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM]

Another Indian killed

out waves of attacks for the third night in a row after Tehran said it had closed the strait, prompting Trump on Monday to reinstate a blockade of Iranian shipping and propose the fee.

But just a little under five hours before the fee had been due to come into effect, Trump said the strait was open to all shipping traffic except that of Iran. “Based on highly productive conversations with Middle East leadership, I have decided to replace the 20% United States reimbursement fee with trade and investment deals that the various Gulf states will be making into the United States,” he said in a post on Truth Social.)

Condemning Tuesday’s attacks, India called for an immediate cessation of violence, particularly the targeting of commercial shipping and civilian infrastructure, and restoration of “free and unimpeded navigation and commerce through international waterways in the region”.

The incident came days after an Indian seafarer went missing as a Cyprus-flagged ship transiting the Strait of Hormuz was targeted by Iran on Sunday. On

Tuesday, his family in Pune said his death had been confirmed.

“India is deeply concerned by the attacks on two vessels, MT Al Bahiyah and MT Mombasa, during their transit through the Strait of Hormuz today,” the MEA said in a statement.

It said of the total 46 crew members on the two vessels, 30 were Indians. “Of the 12 Indian nationals onboard *MT Al Bahiyah*, one has tragically lost his life and another has been injured,” the MEA said. “Of the 18 Indian nationals onboard *MT Mombasa*, nine have sustained injuries, including two who are reported to be seriously injured,” it said.

(Agencies add: The defence ministry of the UAE said on social media that *MT Mombasa* and *MT Al Bahiyah* were “targeted by two Iranian cruise missiles while transiting the southern shipping lane of the Strait of Hormuz, within Omani territorial waters”. Abu Dhabi National Oil Company’s shipping arm ADNOC L&S said the vessels had sustained “significant damage”.

The Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps (IRGC) said that

two “offending” supertankers had been hit and disabled in the Strait of Hormuz after ignoring repeated warnings, turning off navigation systems and attempting to pass through what the Guards described as a mined route. The IRGC’s statement did not name the vessels or say whether it was referring to the same tankers cited by the UAE Ministry of Defence.)

In its statement on Tuesday, the MEA said: “The Deputy Chief of Mission of the Embassy of Iran in New Delhi was summoned this morning by the Ministry of External Affairs and a strong protest against these attacks was lodged with him.”

“We strongly condemn these attacks and acts of violence targeting seafarers and disrupting free and safe navigation through international waterways like the Strait of Hormuz,” it said.

On the situation in the Strait of Hormuz, MEA’s official spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal said at the weekly briefing on Tuesday: “We are closely following the developments in West Asia. We continue to call for safe and unimpeded navigation and flow of commerce through the Strait of Hormuz. This is key for ensuring energy and economic security of people across the world.”

Dashboard

dead, and seven have been injured since the start of the West Asia crisis. There have been 29 incidents of attacks on vessels carrying Indian seafarers – four involving Indian-flagged vessels and the rest involving foreign-flagged vessels.

According to the ministry, each liaison officer will serve as “the single point of contact for families, coordinating medical updates, travel documentation, family assistance, repatriation, seafarers welfare fund support, outstanding wages, contractual entitlements and other compensations”.

Sonowal also ordered real-time vessel-by-vessel monitoring and round-the-clock coordination by his ministry, in association with the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA), Indian Navy, Directorate General of Shipping (DGS), Indian Missions in Iran and Oman, and other maritime stakeholders.

He directed the Secretary, Ministry of Ports, Shipping and Waterways, and the Director General of Shipping to establish a comprehensive operational

dashboard to account for every Indian on every vessel, irrespective of their flags, operating in the Persian Gulf, Strait of Hormuz and Gulf of Oman.

The dashboard is aimed at providing real-time information on vessel position, ownership, cargo, crew strength, crew welfare, threat assessment, intended voyage, next port of call, and the availability of food, fuel, medicines and communication facilities.

Officials would work closely with Indian Missions in Iran, Oman, the United Arab Emirates and other affected countries in the region to obtain verified and real-time information regarding navigational safety, coastal state advisories, route status, port-of-refuge arrangements, hospitals, medical evacuation, repatriation procedures, management of mortal remains, and the status of ongoing investigations.

The meeting underlined that vessel movement through the affected region should only be undertaken after a fresh threat assessment, the professional judgement of the ship’s Master, and close coordination with competent maritime authorities.

Sonowal told officials that

shipowners, vessel managers, and Recruitment and Placement Service Licence (RPSL) agencies employing Indian seafarers in the region should be immediately made to provide compliance reports and a confirmation that no Indian seafarer was being compelled to sail without adequate information, protection and support.

“The Government of India has communicated with all the multilateral forums of the International Maritime Organisation (IMO) and also with the representatives of the concerned flag administration involved in the multiple incidents that contravened international conventions and fundamental requirement of seafarers’ security and safety, and protection of right of innocent passage for merchant vessels. We will continue to make every effort to ensure resolution of the issues and remain committed to all stakeholders in this trying and challenging time,” Sonowal said.

Criticising the “irresponsible, unwarranted and uncalled for attacks” on cargo ships, he assured Indian seafarers and their families that the government was committed to assisting them at all costs.

Bhojshala dispute

which the Muslim appellants sought an interim stay and the restoration of status quo ante. On Tuesday, a three-judge bench, presided by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant said it will fix the matter for final hearing after two or three weeks.

“Meanwhile... without prejudice to the rights of both sides, it is directed that a separate open space adjacent/ near the subject premises may be provided to the appellant and other members of the Muslim community for offering namaz on Friday between 1-3 pm,” the bench, also comprising Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana, said.

“It shall be ensured that no disturbance is caused to both sides in the performance of religious rites. The arrangement shall be ad-hoc in nature and subject to the final outcome of the appeal,” the bench said.

“The bench also directed that “structural alterations” to the complex, “if proposed by the Archaeological Survey of India (ASI), will not be carried out without leave of this court”.

During the hearing Tuesday, CJI Kant said, “These are very sensitive matters”.

“What is happening inside Court No. 1 can unnecessarily create a wrong impression, a wrong message. We should be extremely careful in using any expressions... The state’s helplessness in maintaining law and order has been noted. That’s why we just thought whatever system is there, if we can list it after 10-15 days before a bench,” he said.

As the appellants pressed for restoring the status quo, as it existed before the High Court judgment, the CJI said: “Please be over-cautious. Let us not pass any order that leads to the creation of tension and a law-and-order crisis at the spot. We are ready to hear the matter on a day-to-day basis... Resolve the issue finally... It’s a matter where both sides, we will request, should have patience.”

The medieval structure in Madhya Pradesh’s Dhar has long been the subject of competing claims. While Hindus consider the ASI-protected complex as a temple dedicated

to Goddess Vagdevi, Muslims regard it as the Kamal Maula mosque. Under a 2003 arrangement, Hindus performed puja at the complex on Tuesdays and Muslims offered namaz on Fridays.

In 2024, the Madhya Pradesh High Court ordered an ASI survey of the complex, observing that its nature and character need to be “demystified and freed from the shackles of confusion”. The ASI report stated that the “existing structure was made from the parts of earlier temples”.

Appearing for the Muslim appellants, Senior Advocate A M Singhvi said the situation which prevailed before the High Court decision should continue. “India is a country with layers of history... If you go behind layers, there is no end. If it’s eye for an eye, everybody will be blind. That’s the rationale behind the 1991 (Places of Worship) Act. It makes an exemption for Ayodhya...,” he said.

Singhvi said some of the disputed sites may have had a temple. “For instance, the Jain temple under Qutub Minar... As a Jain, I was taken there and shown something. But that is no reason to go back on layers of history till time starts... There is the larger public interest of 1991 Act to be preserved. Otherwise, there will be chaos in this country. There will be no end to it,” he said.

Singhvi pointed out that there is an Allahabad High Court order, which said somebody must start a survey of the Taj Mahal. “This can go on endlessly,” he submitted while arguing that the Madhya Pradesh High Court order “does a sleight of hand in interpreting the Act”.

Singhvi said there is a continuous history of 700 years of daily namaz at the spot and also cited records, which name the mosque. He described the 2003 arrangement as an “excellent example of communal harmony.”

Senior Advocate Huzefa Ahmadi, also appearing for the Muslim parties, said, “Today, we have been completely ousted. And it’s completely unfair.” Ahmadi contended that

the matter raised several questions, including reliance on ASI reports, and said that those who prepared were not even cross-examined.

Solicitor General Tushar Mehta, who appeared for the Madhya Pradesh government, said that two months had passed since the High Court order and there are several administrative problems in restoring status quo.

“Several things have happened... Right now, your Lordships’ suggestion that it may be heard at the earliest, we can assist on that. We have ensured that both communities keep calm... Once you come after two months and seek status quo ante, administrative problems come.”

When one of the parties pointed out that the plea had been filed much earlier, the bench said no urgent hearing was sought on it. The CJI said the earlier interim arrangement was before the matter was decided by the High Court but now, rightly or wrongly, there is a judicial determination of the character of the place.

Ahmadi said, “We have been elbowed out, and we are sought to be presented with a fait accompli... In all fairness, is it proper to oust out one community, which has been there for many, many years?”

The CJI, too, stressed the importance of appealing without delay in such matters. “In some matters, even a day of delay can have serious consequences,” he said. Justice Bagchi also pointed out that some of the directions in the Madhya Pradesh High Court judgment have already been given effect to.

Appearing for the Hindu parties, Senior Advocate Guru Krishnakumar opposed the prayer for restoring status quo ante in brief submissions.

The arguments also briefly touched upon the High Court’s direction to the Central government to bring back the Goddess Saraswati idol from the London Museum.

Justice Bagchi said, “We do not want, as a constitutional court, to make any comment about all the artefacts in foreign museums of colonised countries, but at least one Indian court has issued a mandamus to the government to bring back an idol.”

Forced labour

conducting an enquiry by the DGFT into the use of forced labour. The provisions of this notification shall come into effect after the expiry of 30 days from the date of its publication in the Official Gazette,” the notification said.

A senior Government official told *The Indian Express* that there are already certain provisions within existing regulations to take care of issues like forced labour, but the July 13 notification is “explicitly stating” it.

The official said that the use of “suo motu” makes it clear that we are not dependent on a complaint to take action. “We had implicit powers, but we have made it explicit, and it may have implications in the discussions that are going on,” the official said, hinting at the ongoing trade deal negotiations with US.

While India has sought the review of proposed US tariffs of 12.5% citing inconsistencies in its Section 301 investigation, Joint Secretary in the Department of Commerce Brij Mohan Mishra, during a public hearing last week, said the country takes the elimination of forced labour seriously as a constitutional obligation, and as a matter of international law and principle.

According to international standards, forced labour means all work or service that is exacted from a person under threat of penalty and not offered volun-

tarily.

Manoj Mishra, Partner and Tax Controversy Management Leader, Grant Thornton Bharat, said the introduction of a prohibition on imports of goods produced through forced labour marks a significant policy shift in the trade framework.

While India has so far relied largely on labour and criminal laws to address forced labour domestically, the FTP now incorporates a dedicated trade measure aligned with international standards under the ILO Forced Labour Convention, Mishra said.

“Announced amid heightened global scrutiny of supply chains and the ongoing USTR Section 301 investigation, the move strengthens India’s regulatory framework on ethical sourcing. However, its practical impact will largely depend on the enquiry mechanism and implementation framework to be prescribed under the Handbook of Procedures, which will determine the scope of compliance for importers,” Mishra said.

Agneshwar Sen, Trade Policy Leader, EY India, said the latest move is a pragmatic piece of trade diplomacy. “The 30-day delayed commencement and DGFT-administered enquiry process gives India room to calibrate scope and pace. It converts this instrument into a reciprocal, rules-based instrument po-

tentially usable in future BTAs, that is arguably WTO-consistent,” Sen said.

Former trade officer and head of think tank GTRI, Ajay Srivastava, said the measure will take effect in 30 days, adding that the order establishes a legal framework rather than an immediate import ban. Its effectiveness will depend on how the government conducts investigations, the evidence required to establish forced labour, and the products it ultimately targets, he said. “The US has launched Section 301 investigations covering about 60 economies, including India, and has proposed a 12.5% tariff on imports from India and most other countries under review. The EU and Pakistan are proposed to face a lower 10% tariff after introducing domestic measures to prohibit imports made with forced labour. Against this backdrop, India’s notification signals that it is strengthening its domestic legal framework in line with international standards, a step that could strengthen its position in future trade negotiations and market-access discussions,” he said.

According to GTRI, US authorities consider products such as cotton, textiles, solar-panel polysilicon, seafood, metals, batteries and electronics vulnerable to forced-labour risks, particularly when linked to China’s Xinjiang region. Yet, the US and the EU continue to import many such products from China, underscoring the challenges of enforcing forced-labour rules.



ANKIT SHARMA'S MURDER DURING 2020 NORTHEAST DELHI RIOTS

‘Savage and relentless assault’ on IB staffer, says court on Tahir Hussain’s conviction

Nirbhay Thakur
New Delhi, July 14

FINDING THAT the prosecution had proved its case “beyond reasonable doubt,” the Delhi court convicted former AAP councillor Tahir Hussain of the murder of IB staffer Ankit Sharma (26) during the 2020 Northeast Delhi riots. The court said Hussain was part of a “heavily armed” mob that abducted Sharma before killing him in what it described as a “savage and relentless assault upon his person.”

Relying on the testimony of five eyewitnesses, the court found that prosecutors had proved beyond reasonable doubt that Hussain was part of a large mob that had gathered at Chand Bagh Pulia around 5 pm on February 25, 2020.

“...accused Tahir Hussain at around 5.00 p.m on 25.02.2020, was a member of a large crowd and unlawful assembly which, with animus against Hindus, had assembled at Chand Bagh Pulia with a common object to commit rioting, loot, arson and to cause damage to the property and person of the members of the Hindu community,” ASJ Praveen Singh said.

The finding was based on the testimony of five eyewitnesses: Pradeep Verma, a parking lot operator; Aakash, a tea vendor and long-time Khajuri Khas resident; his brother Bharat; Deepak Pradhan, a Chandu Nagar resident; and advocate Priyanka Gaur, who lived in Moonga Nagar on Karawal Nagar Road.

The court also ruled that any “prudent” person who is a part of an unlawful assembly knows that in such clashes members of the opposite community could be killed.

“Hence, any prudent person, being a member of this assembly, would have known...in such clashes which were based upon communal hatred, it was likely that a person belonging to the opposite community could be killed,” ASJ Singh said.

Key witnesses

The court relied on the testimony of five eyewitnesses who said they saw Tahir Hussain in the mob. One of them deposed in court that “Tahir Hussain was... stating that Hindus had vandalised and burnt Muslim houses and shops and had molested Muslim women, and therefore the ‘Kafirs’ should be taught a lesson”.

The witness went further,



Ankit Sharma

stating that the mob “assaulted a boy (Sharma) with knives, dandas (sticks), swords, bricks and iron rods and threw him into the drain from the opposite side.”

Another eyewitness said that he saw a 20 to 25 people assaulting a young boy while Hussain was standing in front of the mosque, saying “maaro maaro”. He also deposed that the body was thrown into a drain. Another eyewitness said that Hussain “was joining the mob off and on and, in between, would return to his house”. Another witness said she allegedly saw Tahir in the mob, which was carrying dandas, petrol bombs and stones.

Police witness

The prosecution examined 91 witnesses. Other than the five eyewitnesses, it also cited two police witnesses (then head constables). The court noted that there were “considerable improvements” in the statements of these two witnesses who claimed to have been on duty at Main Karawal Nagar road on February 25, 2020.

“...However, when asked, whether these facts which they had added...instead of putting forward an explanation for not stating these facts, they either simply admitted not stating these facts, or stated that they did not remember whether these facts were stated or not. The improvements made by these witnesses are not minor variations, embellishments or small additions...” ASJ Singh said in his judgement.

Defence arguments

Defence lawyers challenged the testimonies of witnesses saying they were either “chance” witnesses — discovered by the Investigating Officer by chance and who identified the accused by chance — or “stock witnesses”, who were witnesses in multiple FIRs. The court, however, rejected these arguments.

“...merely because they were the passers-by, that too at a place not far away from their house, these witnesses cannot be termed as chance witnesses to strike at their credibility.”

Court relies on the testimony of key witness to convict four and acquit two

Sohini Ghosh
New Delhi, July 14

WHILE THE trial court found prosecution witness Pradeep Verma to be credible despite his being cited as a witness in nine other riot-related FIRs, it relied on his testimony to convict four accused, including Tahir Hussain, but declined to rely on the same to convict two others who were acquitted.

Verma, who ran a parking lot at Khajuri Khas, claimed to have witnessed the rioting in the area on February 25, 2020, when IB staffer Ankit Sharma was killed. The defence argued that Verma was running an illegal parking lot and was therefore under police pressure to depose falsely. Verma denied the allegation.

Also, while Verma initially denied seeing Hussain in the mob, he later said that he felt Hussain was near Chand Bagh Pulia, though he did not actually see him among the mob.

While Hussain argued that Verma was the only prosecution witness “who could have witnessed the incident” and relied on him as a “truthful and natural witness”, the other accused contended that his testimony could not be relied upon.

The judge also noted, “I find it interesting to note that as per one set of accused, (Verma) is one of the most natural witness who could have clearly seen this incident, whereas to some other accused, he not only is a chance and partisan, but he could not have been in a position to see anything...”

The court, however, rejected that Verma could not be termed either a “chance” or a “partisan” witness. It observed



At least 53 people were killed in the riots in 2020. FILE

that although he had been cited as a prosecution witness in several riot-related cases, there was no material to show that he had been a witness in any criminal case before the 2020 riots.

Tahir Hussain

The court examined seven prosecution eyewitnesses to establish Hussain's involvement — two being police eyewitnesses, who were deemed to be not credible by the court, and the remaining being public witnesses, one of which was Verma.

The court recorded that Verma had “turned hostile” and not supported the prosecution's case that Hussain was part of the unlawful assembly or instigating the mob. Ultimately, it relied on Verma's testimony, along with that of others to hold that the prosecution's case against Hussain has been proved for charges of rioting and murder, while acquitting him for the charges of instigation, abetment, exhorting the mob and criminal conspiracy.

Nazim and Kasim

In their case, the court had to solely rely on Verma's testimony after it found another witness to be unreliable. Nazim and Kasim

were identified by Verma, who said Nazim was carrying a knife in his hand on February 25.

The court relied on Verma's identification of Nazim and Kasim as members of the mob, despite his having mistakenly identified another accused, Hassan, as Nazim. It concluded, “Merely because a confusion appeared and it was allowed to remain by the defence as well as the prosecution, the original identification of accused Nazim by this witness cannot be wished away.” It convicted both for rioting and murder.

Javed

Again, the court noted that the only witness to establish the accused as a member of the mob was Verma. Javed had questioned Verma's credibility because he had earlier identified him in another riot case (FIR 98/2020) lodged at Khajuri Khas police station, in which he was later discharged.

The court, however, reasoned that the discharge order reveals that “there is not a single sentence written about the credibility of this witness”, and rather the discharge had followed owing to Verma being the sole witness in the case...” The

court held Javed to be guilty of rioting and murder.

Firoz

The court declined to rely solely on Verma's testimony against Firoz. Firoz had contended that “due to personal reasons”, Verma had falsely implicated him. Initially, Verma had denied knowing Firoz. But Firoz had said that during Verma's testimony in riot case (FIR 98/2020), Verma had deposed that he had known Firoz “for about 10-12 years...”.

The court concluded that Verma “may have deposed against him due to ulterior motives”. It held that it will be unsafe to convict Firoz solely on the basis of Verma's testimony, without corroborative evidence. The court acquitted Firoz of all charges.

Muntazim alias Musa

The prosecution solely relied on Verma's testimony to prove its case against Muntazim. He was identified by Verma more than two years after the incident, in November 2022. Owing to the delay, the court held that the accused's arrest did not inspire confidence and acquitted him of all charges.

ED arrests Ebix chairman in Mahadev app case

Express News Service
New Delhi, July 14

THE Enforcement Directorate (ED) has arrested Ebix Chairman Vikas Garg in connection with its money laundering probe linked to the Mahadev online betting app case, officials said.

Garg was arrested from his Delhi home and produced before a special court, which granted the agency 24-hour custody to take him to Raipur in Chhattisgarh where the probe is taking place. He is expected to be produced before the PMLA Court in Raipur on Wednesday.

The arrest comes weeks after the ED provisionally attached properties worth Rs 940.77 crore belonging to Garg, his family members, and entities allegedly owned or controlled by him. The attached assets include residential properties, land parcels, equity shares and other securities. "The attachment forms part of the money laundering probe into the Mahadev Online

Book/ Skyexchange illegal on-line betting case," an official said.

The ED has alleged that proceeds generated through the illegal betting app were routed into these entities and layered through companies. “The funds were allegedly used for acquiring shares, securities and other assets. Garg is the promoter of three listed companies — Vikas Ecotech Limited, Vikas Lifecare Limited and Eraaya Lifespaces Limited,” a source said.

The ED found that Garg had allegedly acquired a 64% stake in EbixCash through Eraay a Lifespaces Limited using funds suspected to have been generated from illegal betting. The ED initiated its probe based on an FIR registered by the Chhattisgarh Police in Durg, along with other FIRs registered in Chhattisgarh, Andhra Pradesh, West Bengal and other states.

“The betting syndicate allegedly operated through a

franchise-based panel network run from abroad and generated proceeds of crime of over Rs 450 crore per month through illegal betting operations,” an ED spokesperson alleged.

“The probe also revealed that the proceeds of crime generated from Mahadev Online Book and Skyexchange were allegedly laundered through a multi-layered structure of accommodation entries arranged against cash...,” the spokesperson said.

‘Do not abduct Khalra again... I want Centre to have a larger heart, let us tell his story’

i-st h d h i-t s, e i-d e /s ie ie 1- al y d h is g- ie o

THE DILJIT Dosanjh-starrer, *Satluj*, has been mired in controversies — a long censorship battle, a silent OTT release, and an abrupt takedown. Based on the life of human rights activist Jaswant Singh Khalra, it released on ZEE5 on July 3, but was blocked in India within 48 hours, and later taken down worldwide. **JASPREET SINGH** spoke to the movie’s director, **HONEY TREHAN**, whose earlier works include the Netflix show *Raat Akeli Hai*. Excerpts:



It was a hush-hush release. Even the teasers came out after the release on ZEE5. What was behind the decision?

That was a decision taken by my producers and the platform, because every time we announced the release, we were pressured by the government and had to stall the release. So it was completely their call that let’s just release it without any promos. I got to know about the release a couple of days beforehand; the producers called and said ZEE5 wanted to release ‘Punjab ’95’ under another title. I had no issues with that. I just told them there should be no cuts at all. They agreed. I told them we also have the name *Satluj* registered with us. Then we released it.

The movie was blocked in India within 48 hours, and later taken down from ZEE5 worldwide. What was your reaction?

I was heartbroken...The ban pushes you into a corner, and you’re forced to ask yourself...are we seriously living in a democratic country? You see, 31 years ago, Jaswant Singh Khalra was abducted and killed by the Punjab Police. Back then, the Centre (CBI) had played a great role in delivering him justice. Today, after 31 years, Khalra is being abducted again... All I ask of the Centre is that please have a big heart, please be kind towards us, and let us tell his story to the world. Do not abduct Khalra

again. I want the Centre to have a larger heart and give him the freedom... Let his story be told...

The government panel says the film might be misused by hostile elements, Pakistan or separatists...

Are there any grounds for this statement? On the contrary, my film has actually united Punjab. You go to Punjab and see, people are watching the movie together. They say my film is polarising society and dividing Hindus and Sikhs, but on the ground, the Hindus and Sikhs of Punjab are watching the movie together. It was not meant to provoke anybody. My film is a balm on the wounds of the people who suffered so much...

I don’t think there was any reason to ban it. People were peacefully watching my movie for the first 48 hours. But the government banned the movie... It’s been 10 days; everyone’s watching the film... What is more harmful for the law and order of this country? My film that has united people, or hate speeches by the politicians aimed at dividing us? Propaganda movies are also released... And even if you say my movie is a propaganda, then let it be released like you released other propaganda films. Why differentiate? One film can’t destroy our nation.

Some people say the film is one-sided.

If you believe my film is one-sided, then you have clearly not watched it fully... Because if you

watch it, you will hear the exchange between the characters Sugga (Suvinder Vicky) and the CBI cop, played by Arjun Rampal, where Sugga tells him “*ha mari ek ek goli yaha hazaro goliyon ke badle chalti hai*” (Every single shot we fire is in response to a thousand gunshots here). Or the exchange between the characters of the Chief Minister and DGP Bitta, where Bitta tells him that without him, militancy wouldn’t have ended in Punjab. I am a filmmaker; I make my characters speak for themselves. If they can speak for the other side, “*mujhe dhol bajane ki kya zarurat hai?*” (Why do I need to blow their trumpet?) I also mention in the film that thousands of cops were killed in the proxy war. But nobody noticed. How can you say my movie is silent about the other side?

The number, 25,000 encounter deaths in Punjab, is exaggerated, some say.

My film is based on Khalra. He always said 25,000 encounters. His speeches are also available on the web. So I need to depict his truth. But for the sake of clarity and being a responsible citizen, I have still mentioned in the movie that it is an estimated figure. Wherever Diljit mentions it, he says “estimated 25,000 extra-judicial killings”.

Critics are also pointing out that you did not portray Khalra’s politics or his advocacy for the Khalistan movement. Why is that?

I read about him (Khalra) in great detail and I know of his politics too. But I was not making the film to scrutinise anyone’s personality... My focus was his human rights work. Does his politics negate that? No case was ever filed against Khalra. Even in the police testimonies, the cops say: “Khalra was such a nice man, why would we abduct him?” So the question is, if he was such a nice man and a law-abiding citizen, why was he abducted and killed by the police? **FULL INTERVIEW ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM**

‘Haven’t had airport drop in 5 months’: Goa’s motorcycle taxis are dying slow death

Pavneet Singh Chadha
Panaji, July 14

“THE BUSINESS is slow and waning,” says Raju ‘Datta’ Naik (73), as he moves his black-and-yellow motorcycle taxi to the front of the queue at the taxi stand in Panaji on Saturday evening.

Naik, a native of North Goa’s Ribandar village, has been a “pilot” for more than four decades. Hailing from a farming family, he worked in canteens before learning to ride a motorcycle. In the early 1980s, when tourism began surging in Goa, he started offering rides to commuters on a Rajdoot motorcycle in Panaji.

“Abhatkar (landlord) rented me the Rajdoot. I would pay him Rs 10 as the day’s rent, get the tank filled with petrol and pocket earnings from the rides. Those were simpler times, and this job was respectable and paid well,” he recalls.

Naik is among the old guard of these riders, known in Goa as “pilots”. Now, making a living

with these iconic motorcycle taxis has become harder than ever. Naik waits for two hours on average between rides. “The last time I dropped someone off at the airport was five months ago. These buses and cabs did not exist earlier,” he said, pointing to the parking area of the bus stand in Panaji.

Last week, Goa Chief Minister Pramod Sawant launched an app, ‘Mhaje Driver App’, for motorcycle taxis, which allows commuters to book motorcycle taxis registered with the Motorcycle Taxi Riders Association. The app aims to strengthen last-mile connectivity and allows commuters to book a ride digitally from anywhere in the state.

At the launch event, Sawant said the number of traditional motorcycle taxi pilots has dwindled significantly due to the prevalence of rental bike services, adding that the government would stop issuing new licences for rental bike operations to protect the livelihoods of these “pilots”.

Motorcycle taxis have been

operating in Goa for decades, dating back to the period of Portuguese rule. The word ‘pilot’ comes from the Portuguese ‘piloto’, meaning driver, and it was colloquially used to refer to the motorcycle taxi drivers.

In 1981, the Motorcycle Taxi Riders Association was registered, and the state government amended the Motor Vehicles Act, paving the way for these pilots to get permits and operate under a legal framework.

As Goa started gaining popularity in the global tourist map and with limited options for public transport, especially in the rural talukas, the motorcycle taxis soon became a ubiquitous part of the daily commute for locals and tourists in the coastal state.

Avinash Naik (70), a motorcycle pilot, remembers ferrying tourists on the back of his Rajdoot and Yezdi motorcycles for sightseeing tours to the popular North Goa beaches. “Pilots had a lot of respect. People trusted us...and still do. We, along with the taxi drivers,



Avinash Naik (70), a motorcycle pilot. EXPRESS

were called the ambassadors of tourism. The tourists would give us generous tips, and we built friendships. It was a relationship of trust,” he says.

Avinash was four years old when his father, a farmer, died. In his teenage years, he worked in printing, which paid little. A neighbour taught him to drive a motorcycle, and he “became a pilot” to make ends meet. “*Tab fursat nhi hota tha a season mein* (We were so busy dur-

ing the tourist season). Often, we skipped lunch. And now, we have to chase the commuters,” he says.

Improvements in the inter-city public bus service network, increasing vehicle ownership among locals, the steady proliferation of rental bikes, and the rise of illegally operated private taxis over the past couple of decades have led to a decline in pilots’ earnings, with many forced out of the profession.

A member of the Goa Motorcycle Taxi Riders Association said the number of pilots registered with the association is around 1,500, while at least 500 are privately operating and are not part of the association. This represents a major dip from the 8,000 bike pilots operating in the state in 1999.

Avinash Naik says he makes around Rs 400-500 per day on average, depending on the length of the trips. “Fuel costs are always increasing, and maintenance costs of the bike are also high. But government-notified fares have stayed constant for years. We are just surviving somehow. During the season from November to March, we get rides, but off-season, business is bleak,” he says.

“Earlier, people would land at the airport and hire a taxi or take our services to go around. Now, anyone can just rent a scooter for Rs 400 a day and drive around. This rental model has killed our business,” Avinash adds.

Several pilots say they were

not taken into confidence regarding the new app launched by the Chief Minister last week. “We do not want to get on the app. It is an aggregator, and it will drive us out of business in the long run. They will undercut us and charge commission. We have seen this happen in other states,” says Rajesh Tayad (32), who has been a motorcycle pilot for a decade.

“Ours is a self-sustaining business. We are not making a lot of money, and whatever we earn goes into sustenance. But there is freedom... *Kisi ka nok-jhok nhi hai* (There is no interference). Once bike aggregators come in, the Goan identity will also be lost, and drivers from other states will be employed,” he said.

The larger concern for the motorcycle pilots centres around one stark reality. “There is simply not enough demand. What will the app do?” asks Shabbir Shaikh (51) from Verem.

Shaikh has been driving a motorcycle taxi for 20 years.

“Why would someone pay Rs 100 when the bus is charging Rs 10 for the same route? And the bus leaves every 10 minutes from here. Unless it is an emergency, and one has to cover the distance in a short time. The buses are now covering internal lanes, in hinterland areas too,” he explains.

“The locals now rely on pilots largely for emergencies — a visit to the hospital, or late-night travelling... and for shorter rides to the offices during the peak hours. The rides are fewer and farther between,” Shaikh says.

Suresh Verekar (58), another motorcycle pilot, says the government’s subsidy to purchase new motorcycles helps, “but if the profession has to survive, the illegally-run bike services need to be shut down and the licences of rental bike services need to be revoked.”

Many said their children don’t want to join the traditional profession. “But I will do it till my body and spirit allow,” declares Avinash Naik.

Staines murder: As convict Dara Singh seeks release, Odisha court told to decide in 1 month

Sujit Bisoyi
Bhubaneswar, July 14

THE SUPREME Court on Tuesday directed the Odisha government to decide within a month on the remission plea of Ravindra Pal alias Dara Singh, who is serving a life sentence for the 1999 murder of Australian missionary Graham Staines and his two minor sons.

A Bench of Justices Manoj Misra and Vijay Bishnoi adjourned the matter to August

19 after the Odisha government informed the court that the State Sentence Review Board, which is examining Singh's plea, had sought certain records that were yet to be made available.

"In such circumstances, we deem it appropriate to adjourn this matter to 19.08.2026. In the meantime, we expect that the committee shall take its decision," the Bench said.

Speaking to *The Indian Express*, Singh's counsel A P Singh said the state informed

the court that the State Sentence Review Board had considered 56 remission cases, including Singh's, at its July 6 meeting.

"The state sought more time to verify certain records as Singh belongs to Auraiya district in Uttar Pradesh. The court has asked it to take a decision by August 15," he said.

A senior government official said the state was awaiting records from the Auraiya district authorities.

Singh has been lodged in

Keonjhar district jail for the past 26 years. He moved the Supreme Court in July 2024 seeking remission, stating that he had spent over 24 years in prison and had repented for his actions. He was 37 when he was arrested.

1999 attack

On the night of January 22, 1999, a mob of around 50 people led by Singh, attacked a camp at Manoharpur in Odisha's Keonjhar district and burnt alive Staines and his two sons, Philip (10) and Timothy (6), while they were asleep inside a station wagon. According to the police, the attack was linked to tensions over alleged religious conversions.

An FIR was registered at Anandpur police station on January 23, 1999. While 49 people were arrested soon after the incident, Singh remained at large. The investigation was initially handled by the Odisha Crime Branch before being transferred to the

CBI. Singh was arrested on January 31, 2000, in a forest in Keonjhar, though sources had then maintained that he had surrendered. Of the 50 accused arrested between 1999 and 2000, 37 were acquitted within three years.

In September 2003, a CBI court in Bhubaneswar awarded the death penalty to Singh and sentenced 12 others to life imprisonment. The Orissa High Court later acquitted 11 of the co-convicts.

In May 2005, the High Court commuted Singh's death sentence to life imprisonment, a decision upheld by the Supreme Court in January 2011. Odisha Chief Minister Mohan Charan Majhi, who represents the Keonjhar Assembly constituency, had earlier supported the demand for Singh's release. In April 2025, Mahendra Hembram, another convict in the case, was released from Keonjhar jail after serving 25 years on the grounds of "good behaviour".

‘Counsel, you are on mute’

THE WORLD OF VIRTUAL COURTS

The pandemic derailed the best of plans. But this was also the time India’s courtrooms got on to a new track, starting virtual hearings. Despite the chaotic start — patchy networks, and frozen screens and mute buttons — e-courts are now a key part of India’s justice delivery system, write

AMAAL SHEIKH & SOHINI GHOSH

● A YouTube video of the Supreme Court’s *suo motu* hearing into the R G Kar rape-murder case has been viewed 3.64 lakh times since it was uploaded in August 2024 — a number far beyond what could ever have been accommodated inside a single courtroom.

● Last year, a senior advocate logged into a virtual hearing of the Gujarat High Court, beer mug in hand, phone to his ear. The video went viral within hours, and the bench called the conduct “outrageous”.

● In 2022, then Gujarat High Court Chief Justice Aravind Kumar saw Inspector AM Rathod sipping from a cola can during a virtual hearing and directed him to distribute 100 such cans among bar association members or face disciplinary proceedings.

FOR DECADES, India’s judicial system was built around physical files, crowded courtrooms and colonial-era systems. That began changing around six years ago as courtrooms adopted virtual hearings, turning what was a pandemic necessity into a key part of India’s justice delivery system.

Virtual hearings have not only made it easier for litigants to follow their cases but also for lawyers to practise across cities and for citizens to access court proceedings. In the process, they have opened courtrooms to unprecedented scrutiny and transparency, changing how justice is observed and understood.

In February 2026, Law Minister Arjun Ram Meghwal told Lok Sabha that as of December 31, 2025, High Courts and district courts across the country had conducted 3.93 crore cases via video conferencing. E-filing (cases filed digitally) crossed 1.03 crore and 29 virtual courts processed over 94.5 lakh challans, collecting more than Rs 973 crore — figures the minister cited as evidence to say that digitisation of courts has kept the system moving even as courts struggle with case pendency (five crore and counting).

‘People like to come to court’

Fifteen years before courtrooms moved online, the judiciary had begun an overhaul. In 2005, the Supreme Court’s e-committee proposed a blueprint for digitising court administration.

When the project was rolled out in 2007, the focus was on basic digital infrastructure. District and taluka courts were equipped with computers, server rooms and local area networks. Courts adopted Case Information Software, a national case management platform that digitised filing, case records and court administration. Millions of pending cases were entered into electronic databases.

Then, in 2010, came a turning point. India’s first district-level paperless e-court was inaugurated at Karkardooma in Delhi. It was an ambitious shift: touchscreens on the judge’s dais, LCD monitors for viewing digitised records, e-filing to reduce paperwork and facilities for video-linked testimony from jails, forensic laboratories and government hospitals.

Retired Justice Talwant Singh, then the nodal officer overseeing the initiative, recalls, “People were laughing at us... They said, nobody will go for it. Why has so much money been spent? People like to come to court.”

Till 2020, virtual hearings remained an exception. Then, Covid hit, followed by the lockdown. Courts shut almost overnight. And all of a sudden, the question was not whether to go online, but how fast.

The Delhi High Court made the move first. Within 10 days, Justice Talwant Singh conducted what became the country’s first Covid-era virtual hearing on WhatsApp.

The case was a high-stakes anti-suit injunction action against an emergency arbitration in Singapore. A senior counsel appeared from London, and others from across India. “Within two or three weeks, it became normal to hold hearings through VC (video calling),” says Justice Talwant.

Eventually, the Delhi HC moved to Cisco Webex under a proper licensing arrangement and extended it to the district courts.

‘The camera catches all of it’

Confined to a coffee plantation in Coorg during the lockdown, Senior Advocate Sajjan Poovayya appeared before courts across the country. “There would be eight or ten screens,” he recalls. Each screen connected him to a different courtroom.

In the initial days, Poovayya remembers how accidental muting or unmuting, frozen screens and lawyers unfamiliar with virtual appearances became a running joke. “Counsel, you are on mute” became the era’s most repeated phrase.

Senior Advocate Menaka Guruswamy recalls that at first, some senior lawyers underestimated how much a webcam can reveal. “Some didn’t realise that you could be seen very clearly,” she laughs. “If you are a little dishevelled, it captures all of it.”

There were other hurdles. In September 2021, advocate Pratul Pratap Singh, who practises in the Supreme Court, was to speak before a bench, but realised that he could not intervene even after correctly logging in. His senior eventually had to physically go to the court. “I could not unmute,” he recalls.

A person appearing without a lawyer before an SC bench was muted by a moderator just as the bench began dictating the order. For at least eight minutes, the man kept speaking, unheard

Under the virtual system, those whose names do not appear with a designated item number are treated as viewers and cannot unmute and make interventions.

Years later, the system continues to be hobbled by some of these technical challenges.

Often, the virtual system does not keep pace with what’s happening. “It has happened quite a number of times that the judge has gone from case number 10 to 15, and the number on the display board has not been updated by the court staff, and it is still at 7,” says advocate Advait Tamhankar, a criminal lawyer practising in the Bombay High court.

“When we go to the court and say we missed the hearing, they say that there’s no proof that we were online,” Tamhankar says.

In a more sobering episode, a person appearing without a lawyer before a Supreme Court bench was muted by a moderator unfamiliar with the proceedings, just as the bench began dictating a 10-minute order. For at least eight minutes, the man kept speaking, unheard, “even pleading with folded hands,” unaware he’d been cut off, remembers Pratul Pratap Singh.

Delhi ahead of the rest

Advocate Abhinav Sekhri, a criminal lawyer who practises primarily in the Capital, says that during Covid, “in most other states, at best you could have this facility at the High Court level, whereas in Delhi, the focus was on onboarding the trial courts”.

By the end of 2021, he says, virtual hearings had become routine in most of Delhi’s courts. The contrast was stark with Mumbai, where, well into the pandemic, many trial courts remained largely offline and where, advocate Tamhankar says, lawyers still find themselves moving between video conferencing platforms.

Gujarat had been experimenting with live streaming of court proceedings on and off since 2020, when Covid struck. The Gujarat High Court formally went live on YouTube in July 2021 — a first across the country. By February 2023, Gujarat district courts were also live on YouTube.

Since 2022, the Supreme Court has been live-streaming key Constitutional bench hearings on YouTube. Gauhati, Karnataka, Madhya Pradesh, Jharkhand and Orissa High Courts are also live on YouTube.

However, vast differences remain in the adoption of digital infrastructure. In Karnataka, district courts have followed the High Court and embraced technology with surprising flexibility, says Poovayya.

Telangana falls on the other side of the spectrum. “District courts in our state... not much,” says advocate Asad Hussain, a Hyderabad-based advocate.

Data submitted by the Ministry of Law and Justice to the Rajya Sabha in February 2026 underscores that while district courts under the Allahabad High Court had digitised nearly 169 crore pages of records by December 2025, Madhya Pradesh had digitised 66 crore pages, and Punjab & Haryana 62 crore pages. In contrast, Calcutta’s district courts and Nagaland reported no digitised district court records.



ILLUSTRATION: SUVANJIT DEY

● VIRTUAL COURTS: KEY NUMBERS

3,240	~3.93 crore	11	~35 lakh	~1.03 crore
court complexes, 1,272 jails have video conferencing facilities	cases conducted via video conferencing across HCs and district courts	High Courts have live streaming of court proceedings	daily hits on e-courts portal (covers HCs and lower courts)	cases have been filed electronically through e-filing platform

*Data as of December 31, 2025, as provided in Parliament in Feb 2026

‘I speak freely online’

Guruswamy says live streaming and virtual access have fundamentally altered the relationship between courts and the public, “democratising the practice of law”. Technically, courts have been open to everyone for decades, but most litigants had never heard their lawyers argue, and students outside major cities had rarely witnessed constitutional litigation. “Now, students come up and say they watched the arguments on YouTube before they joined law school,” says Guruswamy.

For lawyers, virtual hearings have cleared logistical obstacles.

Hussain says that earlier, lawyers appearing outside their home jurisdictions often depended on local counsel, clerks and other arrangements, but now, “with a Microsoft Word document, a PDF viewer and a laptop, you are good to go,” he says.

For litigants and clients, the information gap has narrowed. “Clients can see exactly what happened,” Hussain says, explaining that they do not have to rely on the lawyer’s version of events.

That visibility has changed behaviour on all sides. Poovayya credits “a greater number of eyes” with bringing “a level of maturity” to court hearings.

For decades, Pratul says, “what happened inside stayed inside.” Today, a stray observation travels far beyond the courtroom, he says, pointing to CJI Surya Kant’s widely discussed “cockroach” remark.

A clip from the Gujarat HC went viral when, mid-argument, a lawyer was heard saying on the phone, “Tell them my father has had a heart attack... his surgery is going on. I can’t be present”

Poovayya says his work now comes with a different tool kit. He began practising decades ago, when lawyers worked with typewriters, carbon copies and stacks of papers that had to be physically transported between courts. “As the most junior lawyer, you got the last carbon copy, and it was barely legible,” he says.

Today, his chambers have moved almost entirely to digital files, following what he calls a “zero paper policy”. “Now, I have multiple copies of these files on my handheld device that moves with me,” he says.

Also, research on a case happens amid arguments now. Juniors search for points and upload material directly into shared digital files. “Sometimes, in the middle of an argument, my files are getting updated as I speak,” Poovayya says.

Younger lawyers have adapted to the changes more easily. “Six briefs of a thousand pages you can’t carry to court. iPads and laptops have taken care of that,” advocate Tamhankar says.

For Delhi-based Maryam Junaid, who graduated from law school in 2024, virtual appearances are less intimidating. “Because I know nobody is watching me, I can just speak freely.”

For litigants, virtual courts have eliminated the costs of going to courts. Pratul, who is from Badaun in Uttar Pradesh, says this has encouraged more litigants to pursue remedies before higher forums.

Yet, many still believe that something is lost when advocacy moves entirely online. As Guruswamy wonders, “What happens to the introspective quality of a courtroom when everything is being broadcast? There is that element of persuasion in a physical courtroom — nothing can substitute it,” Guruswamy adds.

Pratuls says that in a physical courtroom, “if judges are talking among themselves while you are arguing, even hearing one word can tell you what concerns them.”

Some judges say that in a physical court, it is easier for them to understand the issue, ask back-and-forth questions, and understand body language.

“Hearings are especially difficult when government lawyers appear virtually... They have to submit status reports or records, and often, this is done across the bench. For judges, tallying the online documents becomes difficult,” says a Delhi HC judge.

Individual judges can also lay out the manner and mode of conducting proceedings. For example, in Delhi HC, Justice C Hari Shankar has specified, “Presence of Advocates/ parties who appear virtually would not be marked if their camera is switched off.” Justice Girish Kathpalia has requested all those appearing virtually to “maintain proper decorum”. The Chief Justice’s court, too, has similar standing instructions.

What often tests the patience of judges are unmuted conversations seeping in mid-hearing, cross-communication, lawyers appearing from vehicles or without neck bands, and patchy Internet.

Earlier this year, a court clip from the Gujarat High Court went viral when, mid-argument, a lawyer was heard instructing, presumably his colleague, on the phone, “Tell them my father has had a heart attack and his surgery is going on — I can’t be present.” A brief pause later, he adds, “Let the court order whatever it wants, I will get it changed from the Supreme Court.”

For Poovayya, though, provided the technology works well, virtual hearings can sometimes offer lawyers a clearer view of a judge’s reactions. “Body language, mannerisms and thought process of a judge are often visualised in closer quarters,” he says.

Hussain recalls deliberately joining a hearing in a politically sensitive matter virtually, as the lawyers and counsel frequently spoke over one another. “If the bench wanted to hear our submissions, everyone else had to be quiet because we were the ones appearing online,” he says.

A reality check

The virtual infrastructure has worked with relatively little friction inside jails. The e-Mulakat system allows lawyers and family members to schedule video meetings with undertrial prisoners without physically queuing at a gate.

“No hassles,” Tamhankar says. “You don’t have to physically go to the jail, stand in line, fill out the form, and argue with the jail staff who are absolutely uncooperative. All this is avoided. You sit in your office and, before court hours, talk to the prisoner.”

The next frontier that lawyers are approaching is evidence recording. Sekri describes a recent case where his client in Chennai travelled to a court facility to give a statement to a judge in Madhya Pradesh via a video link. “It was fascinating,” says Sekri. “But these are few and far.”

But for every digital stride, there is a reality check.

India’s first district-level paperless e-court, in Delhi’s Karkardooma Court Complex, is a case in point, offering a glimpse into both the promise and fragility of judicial digitisation. Of the two LCD screens installed in 2010 to view digitised records, neither functions. The server crashed in 2016 and has not been restored since. The system, even today, continues to run on a 2G connection.



For Iran’s third republic, America is the defining question



RAJA MANDALA
BY C RAJA MOHAN

BARELY A week after Ayatollah Ali Khamenei was laid to rest in Mashhad, Iran and the United States are trading blows again. The collapse of the ceasefire and the intensification of military hostilities in the Gulf is a reminder that the “third republic” now emerging in Tehran is being forged in the crucible of war and peace with America.

Iran’s internal rearrangement after Khamenei cannot be separated from its prolonged conflict with the US. The nature and terms of engagement with Washington have become the principal fault lines in the struggle to shape the new political order in Iran. The Indian foreign policy community must come to terms with post-Khamenei Iran entering a period of internal restructuring and external reorientation, with important consequences for India’s interests in the Middle East and beyond. It must also pay more attention to the internal debates in Iran on the nation’s future.

For nearly four decades, Khamenei stood at the apex of a state that combined clerical authority with the expanding power of the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps. The transition to a new order was bound to be contested. The American-Israeli military campaigns of 2025 and 2026, culminating in

Khamenei’s assassination earlier this year, compressed what might have been a gradual political transition into an abrupt one.

The swift elevation of Mojtaba Khamenei as Supreme Leader has not resolved the deeper questions surrounding the succession. There is intense jockeying among the different factions constituting the Iranian establishment. As the anti-government demonstrations at the turn of this year have shown, there is also a serious questioning of the political legitimacy of the Islamic Republic.

What distinguishes Iran’s transition is that it is unfolding in a state of conflict and engagement with the US. The nuclear question, sanctions relief, Gulf security, navigation through the Strait of Hormuz, and Iran’s regional role are all now in play. Every choice the new Iranian leadership makes about escalation or restraint is also a choice about the internal balance of power — and every internal realignment reshapes Iran’s capacity to make war or peace with Washington.

To see where post-Khamenei Iran might be heading, it is useful to view the Islamic Republic’s evolution in two distinct phases. The first republic emerged from the 1979 revolution under Ayatollah Ruhollah Khomeini. It was defined by revolutionary mobilisation, the Iran-Iraq War, and the transformation of a broad anti-monarchical movement into a state dominated by the clergy. Institutions were built around the doctrine of *velayat-e-faqih* that places ultimate authority in the hands of the religious figure.

The second republic belonged to Khamenei. He inherited a country devastated by the eight-

For realists, the question is about the nature and degree of change in Iran. Iran’s relationship with America sits at the heart of the unfinished debate on the organising principles of the third republic

year war with Iraq and rebuilt the Islamic Republic into a more resilient and centralised state. Domestic dissent was tightly regulated, while the Revolutionary Guards evolved into one of the country’s most powerful military, political, and economic institutions.

Externally, Khamenei’s Iran pursued influence across the Middle East through proxies such as Hezbollah and Hamas, invested heavily in military capabilities, and presented itself as the principal centre of resistance to American and Israeli power. The result was a formidable regional presence, but also a deepening economic crisis at home and strained ties with most Gulf Arab neighbours.

The burial of Khamenei marks the symbolic end of Iran’s second republic and the uncertain beginning of a third. Every revolutionary state eventually reaches a point where preserving the state matters more than perpetuating the revolution at home and promoting it abroad. Iran may now have arrived at that moment.

For realists, the question is about the nature and degree of change in Iran, not the inevitability of it. Iran’s relationship with America sits at the heart of the unfinished Iranian debate on the organising principles of the third republic.

The first republic under Khomeini was defined by revolution. The second under Khamenei consolidated that revolution through stronger state institutions, the expansion of the Revolutionary Guards, and sustained resistance to the United States. The third, if it takes shape, will almost certainly be defined by how it answers the American question — whether to persist with confrontation or negotiate a

durable accommodation.

That Iran was negotiating with Washington within weeks after the assassination of the Supreme Leader and that talks were going on over the last weekend even amid the mounting military tensions show the difficulty of abandoning the engagement with America. They also show how hard it is to generate an Iranian internal consensus on the engagement with the United States.

Within Iran, hardliners want revenge — in the form of “death to Trump” for the killing of late Khamenei and the continuation of the war against America. Moderates defend the negotiations with the US by calling them a different form of war. Pragmatists argue that a permanent confrontation with America is bankrupting Iran and is unsustainable. The factional lines of the third republic are being drawn around this divide — over the nature, sequence, and the terms of engagement with the US. Beyond the establishment are those that demand an end to the Islamic Republic.

The Islamic Republic was born in revolt against America, and consolidated under Khamenei through resistance to Washington. Tehran is now in the throes of deciding whether its third incarnation of the Islamic Republic can be built on an accommodation with America. The resolution of that issue, in whatever form, will shape the geopolitics of the region and generate new imperatives for India’s Middle East policy.

The writer is contributing editor on international affairs for The Indian Express. He is distinguished professor at the Motwani Jadeja Institute of American Studies, and Korea Foundation Chair on Asian Geopolitics at the Council on Strategic and Defence Research, Delhi

One deletion and cascading civil disabilities



JOHN BRITTAS

WHEN A nation turns alien to one of its own, it does so not with conquest but with the quiet stroke of a pen. R Rajagopal, former editor of *The Telegraph*, watched his name vanish from West Bengal’s electoral rolls in a routine revision, stripping him of his vote and stalling his passport.

The furore over the denial of his passport (which he eventually received), and the remarks by Bombay High Court judge Madhav Jamdar affirming the fundamental right to protest, have brought in some fresh air. Yet the warning remains. The state that begins by forgetting its people on paper can end by making them strangers in their own land.

Every constitutional democracy must revise its electoral rolls. Every sovereign nation must verify the credentials of those to whom it issues passports. Every statute has its own purpose, every authority its own jurisdiction and every administrative process its own legal consequences. What should concern us is when the consequence of one statutory process begins to migrate into different legal domains, producing disabilities that Parliament never contemplated and the governing statute never authorised.

The Constitution deliberately fragments public power. That is one of liberty’s most effective safeguards. The Passport Authority administers the Passports Act. The Election Commission administers the Representation of the People Act. Citizenship is governed by the Citizenship Act. Income tax authorities administer fiscal legislation. Each functions within defined legislative boundaries. The rule of law depends as much upon this institutional separation as upon judicial review itself. The concern arises when the boundaries begin to dissolve.

The Special Intensive Revision (SIR) was conceived as an electoral exercise to improve the accuracy of electoral rolls. It was never intended to become a parallel mechanism for regulating passports, licences, welfare benefits or other civil rights. Whether the SIR has been properly conducted or whether individual deletions are justified are questions that belong to electoral law and, where necessary, to constitutional adjudication. The constitutional concern here arises when

the consequences of an electoral exercise begin to migrate into statutory fields for which Parliament has prescribed entirely different legal frameworks. Suppose electoral exclusion starts affecting passport renewal. Tomorrow it may influence professional licences, public employment, banking, taxation, education, welfare entitlements or even the right to file a writ petition before the Supreme Court (SC) — not because Parliament has legislated such consequences, but because one administrative authority begins relying upon another’s conclusions without independently applying the statute it administers.

Administrative law has long resisted this. SC’s decision in *Maneka Gandhi* transformed passport administration by insisting that restrictions on personal liberty must satisfy standards of fairness, reasonableness and due process. The judgment constitutionalised administrative discretion itself. Public authorities may no longer act mechanically. They must independently apply the law governing them. If deletion from the electoral roll becomes sufficient to deny passport renewal, an electoral exercise acquires consequences never contemplated by the Passports Act. The issue then becomes a question of constitutional method.

The danger, therefore, is not that one journalist may temporarily remain without a passport. The greater danger is the emergence of what may be called a “cascade of civil disabilities” where the consequence of one administrative process travels across multiple statutory regimes until a single determination begins to shape rights.

That is why the present controversy deserves attention far beyond the immediate facts. It is not fundamentally about passports. It is about preserving the constitutional discipline that every public authority must remain faithful to the statute it administers, every restriction upon liberty must have legislative authority, and every citizen is entitled to have his rights determined by law, not by the unintended spillover of administrative decisions.

(with inputs from Aneesh Babu)

Brittas is a CPI(M) Rajya Sabha MP



GOWD KIRAN KUMAR

In Census, caste category must not be open-ended



GOWD KIRAN KUMAR

RECENT NEWS reports indicate that the rehearsal for the second phase of Census 2027 includes an “open column” for recording caste. While the government has clarified that the final methodology will be decided after evaluating feedback from the test exercise, experience from previous surveys suggests that relying solely on an open-text response without a standardised coding framework can undermine the objective of caste enumeration.

The experience of the Socio-Economic and Caste Census (SECC), 2011 is a cautionary example. The use of an open column resulted in over 46 lakh different caste entries, largely due to spelling variations, regional names, sub-castes, synonyms, and inconsistent reporting. As a result, the data could not be effectively classified or officially released for policy purposes. This stands in contrast to earlier and more structured exercises. The 1931 Census recorded approximately 4,147 castes, while the Anthropological Survey of India identified around 6,325 castes in 1951. More recently, states that adopted a standardised coding methodology have shown that accurate enumeration is feasible and reliable.

The Bihar Caste Survey (2023) identified 209 castes, including 112 in the recognised state list of Extremely Backward Classes, 30 under OBCs, 22 SCs, 32 STs, seven Upper Castes, and two Other Related Castes. The Telangana Socio-Economic, Educational, Employment, Political and Caste Survey, 2024 identified 242 castes: 133 Backward Classes, 59 Scheduled Castes, 32 Scheduled Tribes, and 18 Other Castes. Both relied on officially recognised caste lists and assigned standardised codes to each caste, ensuring consistency and minimising duplication.

As the Union government finalises the methodology for Census 2027, it must constitute an expert committee to determine the authoritative source for caste coding. The committee should examine what the framework should be based on: State-wise lists of SCs, STs, and OBCs; the central list of OBCs maintained by the National Commission for Backward Classes; the caste database maintained by the Anthropological Survey of India; or a harmonised national master list integrating these while accommodating state-specific variations. The identification of Upper Castes also requires a clear framework. Since EWS certificates are issued to persons belonging to communities not included in the SC, ST, or OBC categories, the government already has an administrative basis for identifying such communities. This can be refined and incorporated into the Census coding methodology. An open column should remain available only to capture genuine omissions, new caste names, or regional variations.

A well-designed caste census is not merely about counting communities; it is about generating accurate data to identify deprivation, measure inequality, and formulate targeted policies for communities that remain socially and educationally backward. The success of Census 2027 will depend on the government’s ability to classify every recorded caste through a transparent, standardised, and nationally accepted coding system.

The writer is national president, All India OBC Students Association

Rising inflation complicates RBI’s choice

RETAIL INFLATION has continued to edge upwards, according to the latest data, driven, in part, by the food, transportation and restaurant segments. CPI inflation stood at 4.38 per cent in June, up from 3.93 per cent the month before. This brings inflation in the quarter to 3.9 per cent. While this is marginally lower than the central bank’s most recent projection of 4.2 per cent — this is also the last inflation reading before the August meeting of the RBI’s Monetary Policy Committee — the MPC’s decision isn’t likely to be as straightforward as it may seem.

Disaggregated data shows that food inflation rose to 5.32 per cent, up from 4.78 per cent the month before, with ginger, tomato and raisin witnessing high inflation. But the outlook for food prices remains unclear. The cumulative rainfall in the current monsoon season from June 1 has been 19.3 per cent below normal. This has had an impact on kharif sowing, with overall acreage down 16 per cent from last year. The sowing window is closing. And as El Niño strengthens, the situation is uncertain, complicating matters for the MPC. Alongside the rise in food prices, the sharp increase in inflation in the transport segment reflects the petrol and diesel price hikes — June witnessed the full impact of the mid-May price hikes — while the increase in food and energy prices is finding its way to the restaurant category. Some analysts expect the pass through of higher input and fuel prices into prices of other non-food items to exert further upward pressure, even if gradually.

In its last meeting, the RBI’s Monetary Policy Committee had maintained status quo on both rates and stance. While crude oil prices have fallen off the highs thereafter, renewed hostilities in West Asia have complicated matters — over the last five days, Brent crude oil has edged up 7.5 per cent. Much will depend on how MPC members view the external and internal risks to growth and inflation. Global central banks have already begun to react. In its June meeting, the European Central Bank had raised interest rates. Its next decision will be announced next week. The US Fed is also scheduled to hold its meeting later this month. Their decisions will indicate the direction of monetary policy in developed economies.

SIR was conceived as an electoral exercise to improve the accuracy of electoral rolls. It was never intended to become a parallel mechanism for regulating passports, licences, welfare benefits or other civil rights

The experience of the Socio-Economic and Caste Census, 2011 is a cautionary example. The use of an open column resulted in over 46 lakh different caste entries, largely due to spelling variations, sub-castes and inconsistent reporting

• GLOBAL

Why Trump backtracked on 20% Hormuz fee plan



SUKALP SHARMA

US PRESIDENT Donald Trump has reversed course on his plan to charge a 20% fee to facilitate the safe passage of commercial vessels through the the Strait of Hormuz.

“Based on highly productive conversations with Middle East leadership, I have decided to replace the 20% United States Reimbursement Fee with Trade and Investment Deals that the various Gulf States will be making into the United States...” he posted on Truth Social, his social media platform, on Tuesday. This came just a day after Trump had announced the 20% fee, sparking scepticism among experts and analysts, given the lack of clarity on how the proposed fee would be implemented — or even calculated.

It is not clear yet why Trump backtracked, and that too this fast. Going by his own statement, the other Gulf states, who are major energy exporters and depend heavily on the strait, might have played a role. Also, the move’s potential impact on global energy and shipping sectors, and Washington’s traditional stance on navigational freedom could have weighed on the US.

The questions over the plan

There were questions about the viability of implementation as well as the legality of any such move under international law and conventions. There was also a big question mark over whether the US would indeed be able to guarantee the safety and security of commercial vessels in the region. So far, its response to Iranian strikes on vessels has been retaliatory, with an evident lack of pre-emptive measures.

The International Maritime Organization (IMO) said that it opposes fees on ships passing through international waterways. “We have always been consistent on our stance on fees – IMO stands firmly against charging fees for passage through straits

Contested routes through Strait of Hormuz

After the interim US-Iran pact, some vessels have been transiting through two routes: one near the Omani coast and another ‘authorised’ by Iran in its waters. Iran, however, has attacked vessels not using the route authorised by it.



used for international navigation. There is no legal basis through which to introduce mandatory tolls simply to transit through a strait,” an IMO spokesperson was quoted as saying.

The initial announcement was also surprising because the US has traditionally called for freedom of navigation in international waterways and has strongly opposed Iran’s moves to charge tolls from vessels transiting the Strait of Hormuz, which usually accounted for a fifth of global oil and liquefied natural gas (LNG) flows before the war broke out. By calling for a fee, Trump potentially handed Iran an opportunity to argue for its own tolls.

“The U.S.A. will be, from this point forward, known as ‘THE GUARDIAN OF THE HORMUZ STRAIT,’ but as such, and as a matter of FAIRNESS, will be reimbursed, at the rate of 20% on all cargo shipped, for any and all costs necessary to do the job of providing safety and security to this very volatile section of the World,” Trump posted on his Truth Social platform on Monday.

In his social media post, Trump did not

The U-turn

Going by Trump’s own statement, the Gulf states, who are major energy exporters and depend heavily on the strait, might have played a role in the U-turn.

The move’s potential impact on global energy and shipping sectors could also have been a factor.

detail how his proposed 20% fee would be calculated. Would it be 20% of the total cost of the cargo on board the ship, or 20% of the cost incurred by American forces to facilitate safe passage, or some other computation? If the fee would have been on the total value of the cargo, the cost of shipping through the Strait of Hormuz would have shot up, which would have notably increased the landed price of the commodity being transported.

Control of Hormuz

Behind this flip-flop by Trump is a battle between Iran and the US to effectively control the Strait of Hormuz.

The interim pact between the US and Iran, which was signed on June 17, promised to open the strait. Since mid-June, vessel movements through the strait have risen meaningfully, even crossing 90 on June 24, with the average being between 40 and 50 on most days, industry data shows.

But these were still lower than the pre-war levels of up to 140 daily transits. With the renewed flare-up in tensions over the maritime chokepoint, vessel transits through the critical trade artery have crashed to the lowest in nearly a month, to levels seen before the US-Iran MoU.

The Strait of Hormuz was free for navigation prior to the war that began late February, but since then, Iran has been claiming sovereignty over parts of the narrow waterway between the country and Oman.

Unlike man-made shipping waterways like the Suez Canal and the Panama Canal, straits are natural waterways. There is generally no transit charge for crossing them, as per the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea (UNCLOS), although some countries do charge fees for services provided to vessels for crossing a few of these waterways. Although neither Iran nor the US have ratified the UNCLOS, it is widely accepted as international law.

Since last week, Iranian forces have targeted vessels for sailing outside the shipping lanes authorised by Tehran. The US has been responding by striking Iranian military targets, and Tehran has in turn been targeting US assets in other West Asian countries. Moreover, Iran announced over the weekend that it was closing the strait to

commercial vessels, and Trump announced Monday that the US was reinstating its naval blockade in the region.

Had Trump’s plan taken effect, it would have effectively forced shipping players to pick a side. They would have had to work with either the US or Iran to transit the strait, which would have also meant that they would have been at risk of being targeted by the other.

During the war, Iran actively regulated the flow of vessels through the strait. Following the June MoU with the US, it continued to insist that vessels should cross the strait only through the routings designated by it, and that too after seeking its permission. Tehran also planned to impose a service fee for transits, but at a later date.

The US has been encouraging vessels to use the strait’s waters hugging Oman’s coastline as an alternative to Tehran-designated lanes. The differences in the MoU’s interpretation and the vagueness in its terms have emerged as the flashpoints.

How it could have hit India

The US president’s plan, had it been implemented, would have been concerning for large oil and gas importers like India.

If a barrel of oil is priced at \$75, a 20% fee on it would have inflated its landed price in India by \$15 to well over \$90 per barrel, as the final price paid by the importer includes the cost of freight and insurance, and not just the price of the commodity.

And the West Asia conflict had already led to higher war-risk insurance premiums and freight charges for vessels in the region.

A 20% fee on the value of the cargo would be exorbitant, according to industry experts, given that the actual shipping cost is usually notably lower.

As India imports 1.8-2 billion barrels of crude oil a year, every \$1-per-barrel increase in oil prices bumps up the country’s oil import bill by up to \$2 billion on an annualised basis. Assuming that 30% of India’s oil imports would still come via the Strait of Hormuz, the 20% fee at an oil price of \$75 per barrel would alone have translated to \$9 billion on an annualised basis of additional cost for oil alone — not to mention LNG, LPG, fertilisers, and industrial inputs.

• LEGAL

Challenges to HC’s Bhojshala order: Scope of powers, ASI survey

Amaal Sheikh
New Delhi, July 14

THE SUPREME Court on Tuesday declined to pass any order for restoring the status quo at the disputed Bhojshala-Kamal Maula mosque complex in Dhar, Madhya Pradesh. It directed that Muslim worshippers be provided an adjacent alternative space for Friday prayers until the court examines the dispute in detail.

The Madhya Pradesh High Court’s judgment in May held that the site’s religious character is that of a temple dedicated to Goddess Vagdevi (Saraswati). It is now being challenged on several grounds.

On site’s character and title

The principal challenge is that the HC “impermissibly delved into highly contentious and complex questions of fact, historical evidence, and archaeological interpretations to determine the ‘original’ character of the monument,” and that such “detailed examination... is beyond the scope of summary proceedings in writ jurisdiction and should have been relegated to a civil court”.

The petitioners argue that although the court repeatedly stated it was not deciding

title, it declared the site’s religious character in terms that had direct consequences for worship rights “under the guise of Article 226”. The law accords High Courts the power to issue writs for enforcing fundamental rights, as well as for any other legal right against the State or authorities discharging public duties.

This challenge goes to the heart of what the High Court did. The dispute arose from a 2003 Archaeological Survey of India (ASI) order that allowed Hindu worship on Tuesdays and during Basant Panchami, and Muslim prayers on Fridays. Hearing connected proceedings filed by Hindu, Muslim and Jain parties, the HC ordered the ASI to conduct a fresh scientific survey.

It examined Section 16 of the Ancient Monuments and Archaeological Sites and Remains Act, 1958, which bars the use of a protected monument in a manner inconsistent with its character. The HC held that before deciding whether the 2003 arrangement complied with Section 16, it first had to ascertain the monument’s true character. It found the 2003 arrangement defective for having been issued without prior inquiry.

Relying on the ASI report, which recorded Paramara-period foundations from

Origins of legal dispute

The dispute arose from a 2003 Archaeological Survey of India (ASI) order that allowed Hindu worship on Tuesdays and during Basant Panchami, and Muslim prayers on Fridays.

Hearing connected proceedings filed by Hindu, Muslim and Jain parties, the MP High Court ordered the ASI to conduct a fresh scientific survey of the complex.

the 9th or 10th century, temple-style pillars and inscriptions referring to “Sharada Sadan”, the HC held that the disputed area of the Bhojshala Complex and Kamal Maula Mosque was that of a temple.

The petitioners do not dispute the survey’s findings, but argue that the report was treated as conclusive without being tested via cross-examination and that it was read selectively. The plea says the report recorded Arabic and Persian inscriptions, material associated with Islamic use of the structure and the continued official nomenclature “Bhojshala and Kamal Maula Mosque”.

On interpretation of law

The petitioners also challenge the HC’s interpretation of the Places of Worship (Special Provisions) Act, 1991, which preserves the religious character of places of worship as they existed in August 1947.

The HC held that Bhojshala fell within the exemption contained in Section 4(3)(a) because it is a protected monument governed by the 1958 Act. It further held that an official 1935 notification issued by the princely state of Dhar, recognising the structure as a mosque, could not prevail.

However, the petitioners argue that the

exemption merely allows preservation and management of protected monuments and does not authorise the courts to revisit the site’s historical-religious character. They say preventing Muslims from offering prayers at the site is a “violation of their fundamental rights to freedom of religion and to manage their own religious affairs”.

On HC’s powers

The petition questions the standing of some of the original petitioners, noting that the organisation Hindu Front for Justice was registered shortly before litigation began and had declared objectives relating to the restoration of places of worship. Such “pleadings themselves disclosed a pre-determined denominational and restorationist agenda directly...” it said.

The challenge also extends to the HC’s directions regarding future administration of the site. The court directed the Union government and the ASI to decide on the administration of Bhojshala while retaining ASI’s supervisory control over the monument. It further stated that if Muslim parties sought alternative land for a mosque, the state government could consider allotting suitable land elsewhere in Dhar district.

• POLICY

In Ravidassias’ Census demand, the role of history, poll arithmetic

Anju Agnihotri Chaba
Jalandhar, July 14

THOUSANDS OF members of the Ravidassia community gathered in Punjab’s Phagwara on Sunday for a religious programme and to renew calls for a longstanding demand: the creation of a separate “Ravidassia religion” category in the Census.

The Akhil Bharatiya Ravidassia Dharam Sangathan organised the programme that was attended by Sant Niranjana Das, who heads the Dera Sachkhand Ballan — the largest religious institution of the Ravidassia community.

The gathering resulted in a letter addressed to the President, the Prime Minister and the Union Home Minister. It reopens a debate that has existed since 2010, when members of the community declared themselves as practising a separate faith. The demand also holds political significance, with Punjab set to go to the polls next year.

Who are the Ravidassias?

Guru Ravidas, a mystic poet-saint of the Bhakti Movement from the 15th and 16th centuries, created the concept of *Begampura* — an egalitarian society and a spiritual vision of a city without sorrow, fear or discrimination. His followers, the Ravidassias, are a Dalit community of whom the bulk — nearly 12 lakh — live in the Doaba region of Punjab. Perhaps the most influential organisation within the community, the Dera Sachkhand Ballan was founded in the early 20th century by Baba Sant Pipal Das. Once closely connected with Sikhism, the dera severed these decades-old ties in 2010 and formally declared a Ravidassia religion.

An incident in May 2009 was one of the triggers behind this assertion. Attackers stormed a Ravidassia congregation in Vienna, Austria, leading to the killing of Sant Ramanand, a senior spiritual leader of Dera Sachkhand Ballan. Several devotees were injured. The incident triggered protests across Punjab and became a watershed moment for the community to rally around a shared identity. Beginning 2010, the dera started replacing the Guru Granth Sahib with its own Granth, Amritbani, carrying 200 hymns of Guru Ravidas, in Ravidassia temples and gurdwaras.

What is the demand and its place in Punjab politics?

The community argues that while Ravidassia has evolved into a distinct religious identity with its own places of worship, scripture, symbols and religious practices, there is no dedicated option for followers to record this identity during the Census. The demand letter cited fundamental rights guaranteeing freedom of religion to support their arguments.

Community leaders say an official Census category would also provide an accurate picture of the size and geographical spread of the faith. Punjab has India’s largest concentration of Ravidassias in India and around 32% of the state’s population comprises Dalits. Dr Kamal Sampla, Akhil Bharatiya Ravidassia Dharam Sangathan, said: “According to the 2011 Census, the combined Ravidassia and Ad Dharmi (another Dalit-led movement seeking separate recognition) in Punjab stood at around 30.95 lakh, accounting for over 11% of the state’s population then.”

The community’s numerical and political strength has even influenced election scheduling. The Election Commission postponed the 2022 Punjab polls after several parties pointed out that lakhs of devotees travel to Varanasi for an annual dera-organised pilgrimage during the period mentioned in the original schedule.

Earlier this year, Prime Minister Narendra Modi visited a dera in Punjab on the birth anniversary of Guru Ravidas and renamed the airport in Adampur after him.

U.S. PRESIDENT SAYS HE TOOK DECISION BASED ON CONVERSATIONS WITH WEST ASIA LEADERS

Trump steps back from Hormuz fee plan in favour of Gulf investment deals

No details given of what Gulf states have committed to

Reuters
Cairo, Dubai, Washington, July 14

US PRESIDENT Donald Trump stepped back from a proposal to charge a 20% transit fee to guard the vital Strait of Hormuz waterway as part of the conflict with Iran, saying on Tuesday he would instead seek investment deals with Gulf states.

US forces had carried out waves of attacks for the third night in a row after Tehran said it had closed the strait, prompting Trump on Monday to reinstate a blockade of Iranian shipping and propose the fee.

But just a little under five hours before the fee had been due to come into effect at 2000 GMT, Trump said the strait was open to all shipping traffic except that of Iran.

"Based on highly productive conversations with Middle East leadership, I have decided to replace the 20% United States Reimbursement Fee with Trade and Investment Deals that the various Gulf States will be making into the United States," he said in a post on Truth Social.

On Monday, Trump told the "Hugh Hewitt Show" that Iran would be hit "very hard tonight, and we're going to hit them hard



Pro-government demonstrators wave Iranian and religious flags in a gathering commemorating the late Iranian Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei at a square in Tehran. FILE

tomorrow. And there's not a damn thing they can do about it". The governor's office of Iran's Qeshm Island, on Strait of Hormuz, said it was hit by a US projectile around 7 pm n Tuesday, Iranian state media reported.

Meanwhile, a US projectile exploded near a water and electricity facility on Iran's Kish Island, the country's semi-official Tasnim news agency said. State media also reported an explosion heard in Andimeshk in southern Khuzestan province.

Iran had earlier hit back by attacking a US Army base in Jordan with ballistic missiles while Bahrain, which hosts a US naval base, said it had fended off an

Iranian aerial attack.

Jordan said it had shot down four ballistic missiles and explosions were heard in Manama, Bahrain's capital.

In the early evening, Kuwait said its armed forces were engaging with "hostile" aerial targets, and the state news agency said sirens had sounded in the country. The worsening attacks had increased doubts that a memorandum of understanding signed last month would lead to a permanent halt in war.

The UN shipping agency said it opposed any fees for straits used in international navigation and that there was no legal basis for introducing man-

datory tolls on strait transits.

Germany's Hapag-Lloyd, the world's fifth-largest container shipping company, said it would be "fundamentally wrong".

Trump said later on Tuesday that he did not like the concept of a fee for using the strait and said countries had called him to say they wanted to invest in the US instead of being charged a fee. It was not immediately clear what Gulf states had agreed to, if anything.

Trump did not mention any commitments by them, saying only in his post: "Investments will be MASSIVE but, at the same time, extraordinarily good for them, and their future."

Israel, Lebanon hold talks to implement framework peace deal

Reuters
Beirut, Rome, July 14

LEBANON AND Israel resumed talks on Tuesday in the Italian capital, with Beirut hoping for progress towards securing an Israeli withdrawal from south Lebanon under a US-brokered deal, although expectations for swift progress were low.

US-led diplomacy has emerged since Hezbollah and Israel returned to war on March 2 amid the wider regional conflict, moving forward despite strong objections from the Iran-backed group, which believes only Iranian pressure on Washington can secure an end to the war and Israeli withdrawal.

Iran had demanded an end to the war in Lebanon as part of its interim deal with Washington signed last month, but the agreement has been shaken over the last week by renewed US-Iranian hostilities in the Gulf region.

Israel's military is occupying what it describes as a "buffer zone" about 10 km (6 miles) into Lebanon along the entire length of the Israeli border. Israeli officials say the zone is necessary to protect northern Israeli com-

munities from attacks launched by Hezbollah.

A meeting in Washington on June 26 produced an agreement that called for an end to the Lebanon conflict, the disarmament of militant groups - an apparent reference to Hezbollah - as well as the deployment of Lebanese troops to the south and the progressive withdrawal of Israeli forces.

Lebanese and Israeli officials will meet at the US embassy in Rome on Tuesday and Wednesday to set out how to implement the framework deal, Lebanese officials told Reuters. One of the officials said moving the talks to Rome would make it easier for both countries' delegations to consult their governments for guidance as they negotiated.

Italian Foreign Minister Antonio Tajani said on Monday that Italy had offered to host the talks to continue work towards a genuine ceasefire in Lebanon.

"We are also very pleased that Rome can serve as the venue for these meetings. In this way, our capital becomes a capital of peace," Tajani said ahead of a European Union meeting in Brussels on Monday.

Congo launches trial of experimental drug for rare Ebola strain

Reuters
July 14

RESEARCHERS IN the Democratic Republic of Congo said on Tuesday they have started enrolling participants in a trial testing Gilead Sciences' experimental antiviral obeldesivir as a post-exposure treatment for the ongoing Bundibugyo Ebola outbreak in Congo and Uganda.

Congo's National Institute for Biomedical Research and France's ANRS Emerging Infectious Diseases, with support from humanitarian aid groups, Alliance for International Medical Action (ALIMA) and Medecins Sans Frontieres, are leading the trial in Ituri province, the epicentre of the outbreak, the agencies said in a statement.

The trial is designed to assess whether post-exposure treatment can reduce the risk of developing Ebola infection after contact with the virus.

The study aims to enroll about 1,000 people aged 12 years and older, who had high-risk exposure to a confirmed Ebola case within the previous five days but have not developed symptoms.

Participants will be monitored daily for 21 days, with a final follow-up at 42 days.

Obeldesivir has shown activity against filoviruses, including the Bundibugyo Ebola virus, in pre-clinical studies.

Gilead said it has donated 2,400 bottles of obeldesivir and 2,000 vials of remdesivir to support the trial.

MOSPI RELEASES NEW MONTHLY INDEX OF SERVICES PRODUCTION DATA ON TRIAL BASIS

Hotels, eateries clock 35% growth, rlys subdued: New services data

Siddharth Upasani
New Delhi, July 14

HOTELS AND restaurants are comfortably the fastest-growing segment of the country's services sector, expanding by more than 35% year-on-year on average in 2025-26 as well as in the first month of 2026-27, according to new data released on Tuesday by the Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation (MoSPI).

The 'accommodation and food' sub-sector is one of 19 — covering approximately 60% of the services sector — which together make up the Index of Services Production (ISP), released for the first time on Tuesday on an experimental basis. Since the data is still at a trial stage, no overall services sector growth number was provided by MoSPI.

However, DK Srivastava, EY India's Chief Policy Advisor, estimated the overall growth at 20.8% in April.

Of the 19 sub-sectors, all but two grew on a year-on-year basis in April, with 14 posting double-digit growth rates. In 2025-26, all but one sub-sector had grown, with output of 12 rising by 10% or more.

The release of the trial ISP data is the latest addition to India's official statistics. It is the services counterpart of the Index of Industrial Production (IIP),

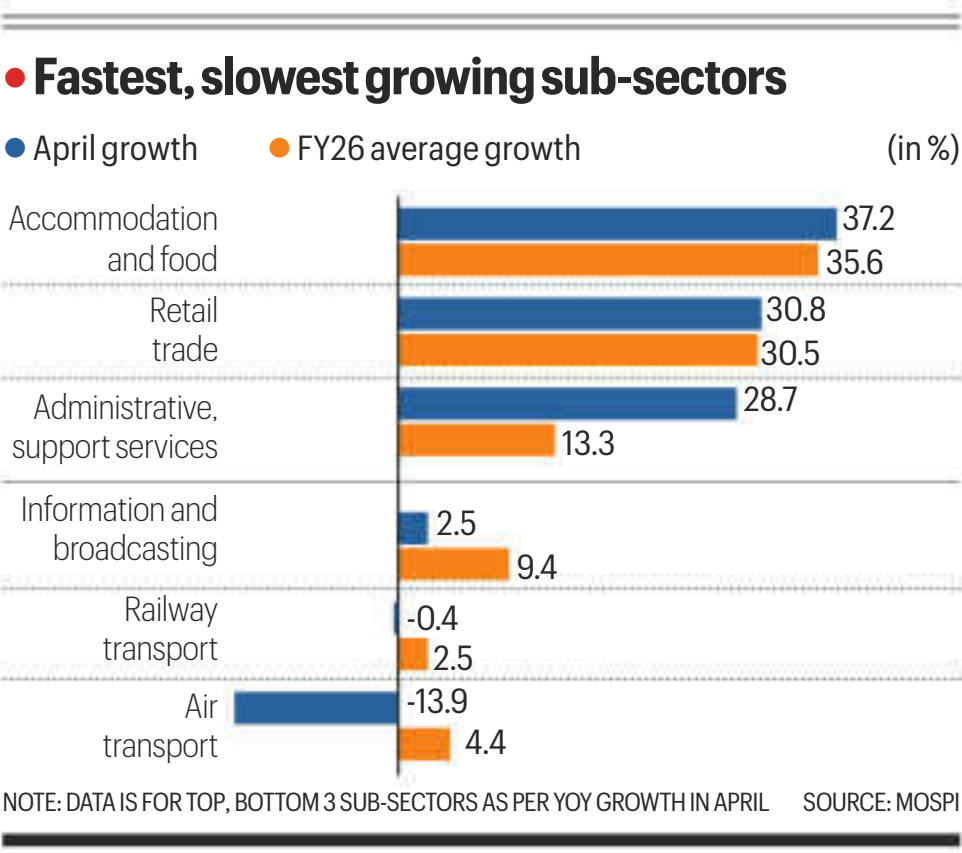
which measures the change in the output of India's industrial sectors: manufacturing, mining and quarrying, electricity and gas supply, and 'water supply, sewerage & waste management'.

The ISP fills a key gap in India's official statistics; until now, there was no official monthly measure of the services sector's performance, with private sector firm S&P Global's services Purchasing Managers' Index (PMI) being the only one.

Services are the biggest contributor to India's economy, making up more than half of it for the last decade and a half or so. Industry, meanwhile, makes up less than a third of the Gross Value Added (GVA).

Measuring production of services is notoriously difficult. As Chief Economic Advisor V Anantha Nageswaran said: "A car leaving a factory can be counted, a tonne of cement can be weighed. But a consultation, software release, a train journey, a loan sanction — these are all produced and consumed at the same moment; there is nothing to weigh or put in a warehouse. Therefore, every statistical system in the world, not just in India, was built first for the factory".

The ISP is not directly compiled as the output of the services produced by various companies; instead, Goods and Services Tax (GST) and admin-



istrative data for sub-sectors like air and railway transport and banking are used. Sub-sectors for which data is available in value terms are 'deflated' by the appropriate price measure, be it Wholesale Price Index or Consumer Price Index, to arrive at the output.

Speaking at the release of the ISP figures, MoSPI Secretary Saurabh Garg said a key feature of the new data series is that its compilation does not place additional compliance burden on companies to respond to a MoSPI questionnaire or survey as it is calculated entirely through data that is already available.

He cautioned that since the ISP is not a measure of GVA — released every quarter with GDP data — it may or may not move in the same direction as GVA growth.

Meanwhile, Nageswaran noted that the use of GST as a key source of data for the statistics ministry shows how a tax reform "has quietly become an information system."

While the 'accommodation and food' sub-sector has grown rapidly, railway and air transport struggled. After growing by 2.5% on average last year, railway transportation services shrunk by 0.4% in April. Air transport saw 4.4% average monthly

growth in 2025-26 but a 13.9% contraction in April. The fall in the air transport index in April came amid the disruption caused by the West Asia war, which led to airlines raising fares on account of higher fuel costs.

The other sub-sectors of the ISP — which has a base year of 2024-25 — are: wholesale trade, retail trade, repair services, road transport, water transport, warehousing and support activities for transportation, postal and courier, telecommunications, information and broadcasting, banking, insurance, real estate, IT and computer related services, 'professional, scientific & technical services including R&D', administrative and support services, and arts, entertainment and recreation.

Health and education are two key segments not covered by the ISP as they are exempt from GST. However, MoSPI officials said the ministry is working on using administrative data to compile the index for health, education, and ownership of dwellings. Once this exercise is concluded, the overall ISP will cover 80% of the services sector.

Core government activity — such as public administration, defence, the Reserve Bank of India — non-market activities, and the informal sector are also excluded from the ISP. These account for roughly 30% of the services sector.

Food price surge pushes WPI inflation to nearly 10% in Jun

Siddharth Upasani
New Delhi, July 14

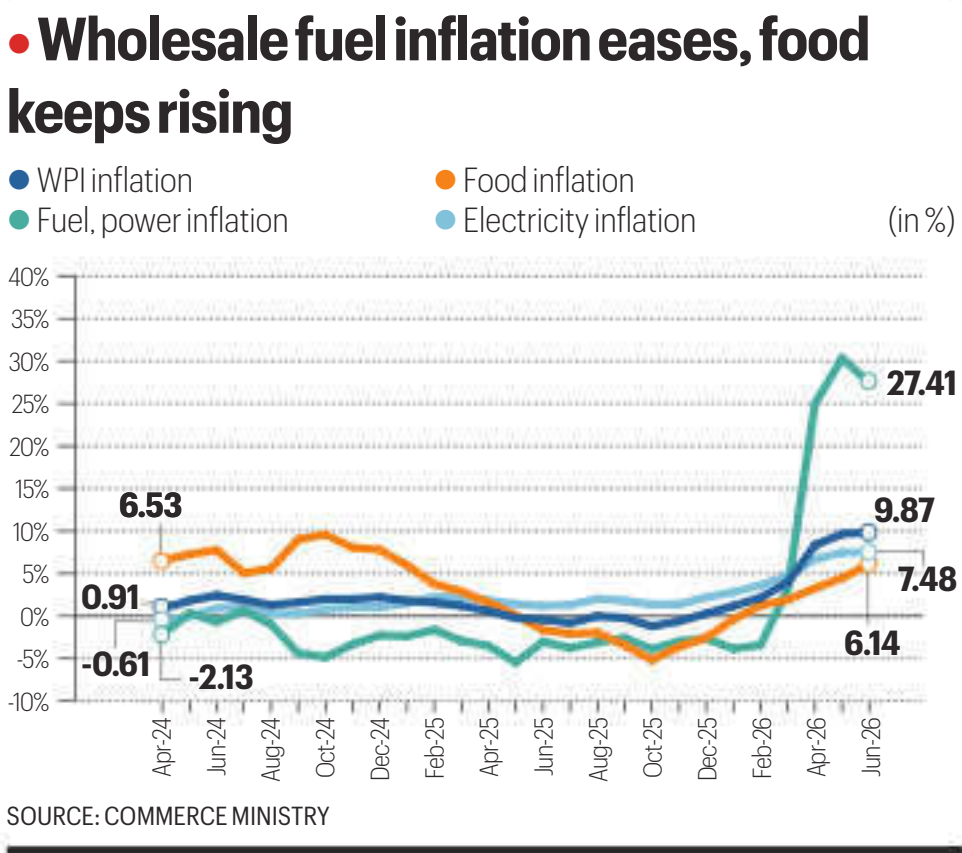
WHOLESALE INFLATION in India almost hit double-digit territory in June, rising to 9.87%, as a sharp acceleration in food price increases more than cancelled out cooling fuel pressures, with economists warning that inflation is becoming "more generalised than before".

Data released by the Ministry of Commerce and Industry on Tuesday showed inflation measured by the Wholesale Price Index (WPI) in June unexpectedly rose from 9.68% in May to the highest level in the current series that goes back to April 2024. This is the second print under the revised WPI series, which has 2022-23 as the base year and incorporates new calculation methods, and a greater number of items, among other changes.

"...since November onwards...the inflation rate (has) drifted from a low negative deflation to this high level in June. Quite clearly the days of low inflation are over," said Madan Sabnavis, Bank of Baroda's Chief Economist.

The WPI inflation data comes a day after the statistics ministry data showed household inflation rose to 4.38% in June — the most in one-and-a-half years — on the back of a continued rise in food prices, as deficient rains and the impact of the retail fuel price hikes hit consumers' pockets.

Tuesday's data showed wholesale food inflation jumped to 6.14% in June from 4.49% in May, driven by huge month-on-month price increases for the likes of drumstick (46%), capsicum (38%), tomato (33%), and onion (26%),



June output PPI inflation at 9.57%

New Delhi: The commerce ministry on Tuesday also released the Producer Price Index (PPI) data. As per this new index, which was first released last month, output PPI inflation rose to 9.57% in June from 9.38% in May. The June output PPI inflation figure is also the highest so far, with data start-

ing from April 2024.

Month-on-month, the output PPI was up 0.3% in June from May, although the index for manufacturing was down 0.3%. Meanwhile, the trial input PPI for manufacturing was up a sharp 2.1% month-on-month, indicating profit margins are under pressure. ENS

Among meats, the price of beef and buffalo meat was up 21% in June compared to May, while eggs were 11% costlier.

The month-on-month increase in the price indices of goods is indicative of the momentum in prices. This is a better indicator of how prices are moving as opposed to the inflation rate, which measures prices compared to last year.

"Food prices have been on an increasing trend since November and reached a 17-month high at 5.5% in June 2026, due to

the base and El Nino effect," said Megha Arora, Director at India Ratings & Research, referring to food articles inflation rising to 5.49% last month.

Meanwhile, 'fuel and power' inflation eased to 27.41% from 30.33% in May. Aastha Gudwani and Amruta Ghare of Barclays estimate that this decline "shaved off 41 bps from headline (inflation), partly offsetting the impact of the increase in food inflation".

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

CBAM'S 2027 DEADLINE NEARS India, UK discuss carbon tax issue: Comm secy

New Delhi: India and the United Kingdom (UK) are engaged in discussions on Britain's carbon tax regulation, Commerce Secretary Rajesh Agarwal said on Tuesday. In December 2023, the UK government announced that it would implement its Carbon Border Adjustment Mechanism (CBAM) starting in 2027.

According to economic think tank GTRI, India's exports worth \$775 million to the UK may be impacted due to Britain's decision to introduce a carbon tax on products, like iron and steel, aluminium, fertiliser and cement, from 2027.

"CBAM is a regulation which is under work. It has yet not come to fruition. Both sides are engaged in discussing CBAM regulation," Agarwal told reporters here.

The UK, after the European Union (EU), will be the second economy to implement CBAM. PTI